Property Finder · Product Builder challenge

Who we are building for, and what 32 live listings showed

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Short-term renter
India → Dubai, first time

“Show me a studio I’d actually like, at the price I’ll really pay, from an agent who’ll reply, and help me remember who I’m talking to.”

Bio

- Sent by her company; stay **3 months, may stretch to 8+**, so she can’t commit to a fixed term
- No fixed office: moves between client meetings
- Doesn’t know Dubai’s areas, rules or hidden costs
- Searches **from India, on her phone**; wants to finalise before landing
- Agents ignore Indian numbers, so **WhatsApp text only**

Needs

- **Studio with a real kitchen** (she cooks; no hotel rooms)
- **Monthly terms**, stated clearly, easy to extend
- **All-in ≤ AED 7,500/mo**: rent + DEWA + chiller + VAT + tourism + service + agency fee
- Safe, clean building; metro walkable or easy cabs; grocery nearby
- Nice: gym (4×/wk), pool, sauna, high floor with a view, spacious

Goals

- A trusted, in-budget studio, found **fast** (peak season)
- Genuine agents who reply; straightforward T&Cs
- A **documented all-in cost** her manager can approve
- Clear deposit and checkout terms
- Short list by taste + clear terms + agents with many reviews

Frustrations

- **Hidden costs**: once exceeded an approved amount; her company asked why
- Bait photos: recycled sets, a different unit sent on WhatsApp
- Re-explains her needs to every agent; some never reply
- **Loses track** across ~10 WhatsApp chats; falls back on Excel
- Can’t visit before booking; lost a deposit before

Listing audit: 32 live studios, Business Bay + Dubai Marina, 12 Nov 2026

30 Property Finder + 1 Bayut + 1 Dubizzle · each opened by the persona and its description checked. Full table:
AUDIT.xlsx → https://github.com/Divyanshisachan/pf-builder-challenge/blob/main/AUDIT.xlsx

- **The real price is unknowable from the listing.** 0/30 PF listings let you compute the all-in cost; VAT, 7–15% service charges and tourism fees appear only in the description. Headline 6,999–7,999 became **~8,000–9,900**.
- **"Monthly rent" is mostly hotel-style short stay.** 29/30 come from holiday-home operators; 2 PF "studios" (+1 on Dubizzle) are hotel rooms with no kitchen.
- **The trust badges mislead.** 29/30 say "~90% below average" by comparing monthly rent with an annual average; like-for-like, most are 12–35% above. 20/30 show a placeholder broker licence (00000, na); 4 show no permit.
- **Photos don’t prove the unit.** 0/30 say if photos are real; one recycled photo set ran across 3 listings; the same Business Bay "area" shots appear on every building, including one on a highway edge.
- **Duplicates and stale stock.** The same unit listed twice (#6/#7); same building and size priced 7,000 vs 7,999 (#14/#28); 14/30 listed 6+ months ago.
- **Listed price ≠ paid price.** The persona rented the sister tower of #25 for AED 4,500 all-in; PF asks 7,999 (~9,900 all-in).
- **What earns an inquiry (12/32):** unit matches her taste + description states bills, monthly terms or a long-term discount + agent with many reviews (3.8 from 104 beats 4.5 from 2).
- **Scout:** not reachable from search; found at /scout/v2 but "access currently limited", so it could not be tested.